

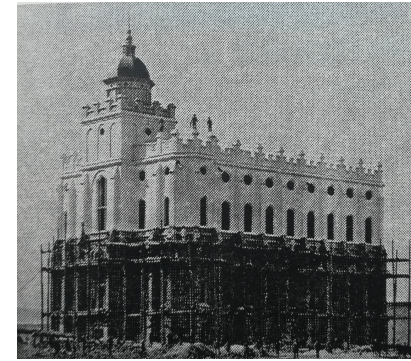


LUNT HOME

First East (High Street) and 100 North, Cedar City, Utah

Left to Right: Mary Ann Lunt, Maude Matheson holding Duayne,
Violet and Ianthe Matheson (twins).

This home was built next to the Lunt Hotel and Stage Stop. Note the
Western Union Telegraph and Cable Office sign on the utility pole.



CHAPTER XXI

ST. GEORGE TEMPLE

1874 – 1877

George A. Smith, who was in St. George, Utah, wrote a letter dated November 26, 1874, to Joseph F. Smith in Salt Lake City. He told of the trip with President Brigham Young to St. George and how ill President Young was on the way. Apparently “the President took cold in Levan which caused rheumatism to settle in his lower limbs.” After they reached their destination, he was able to stop using his crutches when the weather cleared up. Smith wrote that they “had 18 meetings on the way down.” Part of the letter follows:

The extraordinary expenses incurred in building the temple are beyond the income of that office, as the crops in all the counties composing the Southern District have been light and the tithing is, consequently, small. A large number of men have come from the north, and they are moving the temple work forward rapidly at the present time. A great difficulty is to obtain lumber. Our mills at Mount Trumbull are about 65 miles distant, 40 of which are without water, the great difficulty being to get the lumber hauled [it took seven days to haul a load of lumber to St. George]. Snow is now 18 inches deep

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at Mount Trumbull, and we are compelled to carry the hay 150 miles to support the cattle that furnish the mills with logs--and grain has to be hauled much further.

About 100 men are at work in the quarry. The scarcity of money to meet the demands for cash articles is severely felt, both on this and the Salt Lake Temple. The walls of this temple [St. George] are between 30 and 40 feet high, and the work is first-class masonry, every stone being well laid on its natural bed. There is a good deal of spirit manifested by the brethren to push its construction forward. Elder William H. Folsom is now here taking charge of the Architectural Department, and Bishop Nathan Davis of the 17th Ward [Salt Lake City] is here making arrangements for casting the Baptismal Font and the oxen upon which it is to stand. They are to be of Utah iron, finished with bronze. He has visited the iron works at Iron City and is much pleased with the prospect of Utah being supplied with this indispensable metal from our own mines.

Although the grain and hay crop has been lighter than usual, there has been more cotton raised than for several years previous, and the product of Sorghum Syrup is superior in quality and greater quantity than in the last seven years. There has also been a large amount of broom corn raised, which will be worked into brooms this winter. The fruit and wine crop was also excellent

To be successful here, an agriculturist should make his plow overtake the reaper and, as soon as his small grain is harvested, he should plow the ground and plant it with maize. The cultivator, hoe and irrigation water follow, and the second harvest is about as valuable as the first. If this latter crop is neglected, a growth of sunflowers and other wild plants will grow

so rank that the husbandman will have about as much trouble to clear it off and prepare for another crop as to cultivate it as above mentioned. Some of this growth of weeds will be ten or twelve feet high. I have been into the fields to observe this result this season, as well as many times before.¹

On March 5, 1875, the last rock was laid, bringing the Temple to the square, ready for the roof timbers. The craftsmanship was precise and of a superior quality. When this stone was mortared in place, all of the workmen shouted with joy. Erastus Snow was there and, the next morning, they held a three-hour meeting in the Tabernacle. After the excitement and fanfare of the gathering, the numerous workers from other parts of the territory headed home. Many people from Cedar City were among the workers. The local people finished the temple, during which time President Young observed its progress.

Brigham Young donated the baptismal font for the St. George Temple at a cost of five thousand dollars. The 13 by 9 feet font, which was oval in shape, and the twelve life-sized oxen that were to support it were cast in Salt Lake City from the pig iron brought by ox team from Iron City, near Cedar City. Together, the font and oxen weighed 18,000 pounds and were shipped, in parts, on the Utah Southern Railroad as far as Spanish Fork the summer of 1875. From there they were transported in three specially built oxen-drawn wagons. The arrival of the wagon train in each small town along the way created much excitement. No one but the local L.D.S. Bishop, and those who received his permission, was allowed to see what the wagons contained. The weather created a major problem for the transporting of the font. With temperatures exceeding 100 degrees in the shade, some of the oxen pulling the heavy loads nearly died of thirst. When the caravan finally reached St. George, a distance of some 300 miles from Salt Lake City, the men unloaded the font and each piece was carefully carried in and bolted in place. When Apostle Orson Hyde saw it, he wept for joy "that he had lived to see another font in place in a temple of the Lord." The only other baptismal font, up to that time, had been in the Nauvoo Temple.

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Soldiers from Camp Floyd, traveling to Beaver on foot, passed and repassed the wagon train carrying the St. George Temple font. Because John D. Lee's first trial, concerning the Mountain Meadows Massacre, was underway in Beaver, the soldiers suspected cannons or other arms were being shipped south, and they wanted to see what was in the wagons. But the caretakers of the font followed their instructions and did not let any unauthorized viewers see what they were carrying.²

In 1870, through representations of Apostle Erastus Snow and the Bishop of Kanarra, President Young became convinced of the guilt of both Lee and Isaac C. Haight as accomplices in the massacre, the latter for failure to restrain Lee, since Haight was Lee's superior officer. President Young gave instructions at the time that Lee should, under no circumstances, ever again be admitted as a member of the Church. It wasn't until 1875 that his first civil trial took place.³

In 1875 a new cattle company was organized with Henry Lunt as President, Jens Neilson--Vice President, George Wood, John Parry, David Bulloch--Directors and John Chatterley--Secretary. This company was known as the CCCC (Cedar City Cooperative Cattle), and its object was to expand the cattle industry and promote the manufacture of butter and cheese. Capitol stock was sold at five dollars per share. The first cooperative sheep company, organized earlier, was known as the Cedar City Cooperative Sheep Association and had 62 owners. Sheep were valued at five dollars per head. This organization was a successful, dividend-paying company which operated over a period of fifty years. The cattle company was sold to the Bullocks in 1884. The sheep and land were disposed of in 1917.⁴

As Bishop, Henry performed the marriage ceremony of C. J. Arthur and Ann Elizabeth Perry on February 17, 1875. Arthur wrote the following about the occasion:

At half past seven o'clock we were married by Bishop Henry Lunt under the express sanction and blessing of President Brigham Young. The occasion was of especial and unusual favor and one of the most solemn and impressive I ever witnessed outside the

House of the Lord. Bishop Lunt felt unusual, and he administered many blessings. No particular feast, only a little cake, cheese and pie with a little wine were passed to the company.

On February 19, in honor of their wedding, the newly married Arthur's invited Henry and Ellen and others to their home for dinner.⁵

On June 3, 1875, the Relief Society Presidency was released and a new President was called. Ellen Lunt remained as Secretary, a position she held for twenty-three years. Sarah Urie was sustained as President. She chose Mary Ann Lunt and Sage Jones as her Counselors. Sarah was released November 6, 1879. In June 1879, a Stake Relief Society was organized with Ellen Lunt as President. Mary Ann Lunt and Huldah A. Mitchell were sustained as counselors. Later, on February 5, 1892, Mary Ann Lunt followed Ellen W. Lunt as Stake President. In those early years, the Relief Society played a very important part in uniting the women of the community. It helped to raise funds and goods for the building of the St. George Temple and for the Emigration Fund, as well as money to help care for the wants of the poor. The Relief Society members were given the direction to help the church become self-sustaining by doing their own sewing, canning and learning to care for each other.⁶

Mary Ann and Henry became the parents of a baby girl December 18, 1875, whom they named Alice Maude Wilson Lunt. This was the eighth and last child born to Mary Ann. Another baby, Owen Gower Lunt, who died the same day he was born, was born on August 29, 1876, to Henry and Ann Gower Lunt.

The following article appeared in the *Deseret News*, (25:687):

In November 1876 Brigham Young and company visited southern Utah. They arrived at Cedar City, November 7, 1876. A large number of the saints were on hand to greet the president on his arrival at Bishop Lunt's residence where an arch of evergreens was erected across the street decorated with flags and the motto, 'God Bless Our Prophet.'

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A meeting was held in the afternoon at which Elder Wilford Woodruff, President Brigham Young and George Q. Cannon addressed the saints. President Young spoke nearly three quarters of an hour upon the wisdom, duty and necessity of the people working to become self sustaining in tanning, making up boots and shoes, cloth, clothes, hats, etc., for the use of the settlement, and showed the folly of buying five or six mowing machines where only one was necessary, economizing and combining labor and means in a cooperative manner. The meeting house was crowded and the discourse listened to with great attention. The day was lovely, and the spirit of peace enshrouded the whole settlement. Young and company left Cedar City for Bellevue [Pintura] the morning of Nov. 8, 1876.

Wilford Woodruff recorded the events of the first dedication of part of the St. George Temple. He wrote about President Young and a large number of elders of the Church leaving for St. George, "wither they went to dedicate the first temple erected in Utah." President Young was in poor health during their stay there while the temple was being completed. With the St. George Temple being built, Woodruff saw opportunities which the saints in earlier days had not been able to enjoy. "The temple became a haven of rest and spiritual strength." There was, perhaps, no duty or labor more pleasing to him than the ordinances performed in the Temple of God. Woodruff wrote:

This is a very important day to the Church and Kingdom of God on the earth. President Brigham Young and members of the Twelve, with some two thousand Saints assembled within the walls of the Temple in St. George to dedicate certain portions thereof, that we might commence to administer the ordinances ordained of the Lord for the salvation of the living and the dead. President Young was ill and could not stand upon his feet.

At 12:30 p.m. on the first day of January 1877, Wilford Woodruff stood on the upper step of the baptismal font and gave the following address to the congregation:

We are this day blessed with the privilege which very few since the days of Adam have enjoyed. We assemble in a Temple built by the commandment of the Lord for the salvation of the human family. We have met to dedicate certain portions of this building. I realize that this assembly is too large and too crowded to bow upon their knees, but all are asked to bow their heads and hearts unto God. All who are here are Saints, or should be, for none others ought to be in this holy Temple. I want the Saints assembled to repeat the words in secret that our prayers may ascend to the Lord of Sabbath, that they may be answered upon our heads.

Mrs. Susa Young Gates, daughter of President Young, wrote the proceedings of the dedication in shorthand. The room was so packed that there was no place for a table. She laid her book upon the back of the person standing in front of her while she made a stenographic report of the proceedings, which included the dedicatory prayer that was offered by Apostle Wilford Woodruff.⁷

President Brigham Young, the Quorum of Twelve Apostles and other selected priesthood leaders went to the "sealing room" on January 1, 1877, where Apostle Brigham Young Jr. offered a prayer, after which they returned to the main floor and Pres. Young spoke. Temple records indicate that the following thirty-three persons were present in that sacred room:

President Brigham Young, Apostle Wilford Woodruff, Apostle Erastus Snow, Apostle Brigham Young Jr., and Elders Alonzo H. Raleigh, John D. T. McAllister, John Nuttall, John L. Smith, Anson P. Winsor, Charles H. Wilcken, William Crabtree, Henry Lunt, John M.

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Macfarlane, Jacob Gates, Truman O. Angell, Alex F. Macdonald, David H. Cannon, Charles Smith, Joseph Birch, John O. Angus, Richard Bentley, Jesse N. Smith, Morris Ensign, Christopher J. Arthur, James G. Bleak, Archibald Sullivan, John Lytle, Ira Miles, Dan D. McArthur, David Milne, Henry Eyring, Walter Granger, and Nash Ashby.⁸

The first baptisms for the dead performed in the St. George Temple took place on January 9, 1877, even though the Temple was not totally completed. The Temple was finally finished five and one-half years after the building commenced, and three months after the first dedication. A lengthy letter was sent from the General Authorities to the Bishops and general membership throughout the territory informing them of the dedication agenda. Conference was to be held April 6, 1877, at 10:00 a.m. in the St. George Temple in conjunction with the dedicatory ceremony. An article in the *Deseret News* of February 8, contained a caution from the authorities that there was concern because of the large numbers of Saints who were planning to journey to St. George for the occasion. The people of St. George, Santa Clara and Washington were preparing to play hosts to the large groups who were expected to attend.

The April L.D.S. General Conference was, indeed, held in the, just-completed, St. George Temple. This was a great honor for the hardworking Dixie settlers who willingly opened their homes to the church members. The First presidency of the Church, eleven of the Twelve Apostles, the Patriarch to the Church, the Presiding Bishop, and other church leaders, including Stake Presidents and Bishops, were in attendance. Henry Lunt and others from Cedar City traveled to St. George for the proceedings. An account was published in the *Deseret News*, some of which follows:

Friday, April 6, 1877: The forty-seventh General annual Conference of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints convened in the St. George Temple. President Brigham Young presiding. There were

present in the Melchizedek Priesthood stand: Pres. Brigham Young and his counselors: John W. Young and Daniel H. Wells. Also, of the Twelve Apostles: John Taylor, Wilford Woodruff, Orson Hyde, Orson Pratt, Charles C. Rich, Lorenzo Snow, Erastus Snow, Franklin D. Richards, George Q. Cannon, Brigham Young Jr., and Joseph Fielding Smith [Henry's good friend, George A. Smith, was not there, as he died September 1, 1875]. He also invited Presiding Patriarch, John Smith, and St. George Stake Presiding Bishop, Edward Hunter, together with some visiting Bishops [Henry Lunt being among them]. The Parowan Choir sang the opening hymn, 'The Morning Breaks,' then the dedicatory prayer for the St. George Temple was offered by president Daniel H. Wells of the First Presidency.

Wilford Woodruff spent several months in St George doing temple work prior to the L.D.S. Conference that was held there. The following are excerpts from his journal:

Jan. 14, 1877: Spent the evening with President Young. He requested Brigham Jr. and Wilford Woodruff to write out the Ceremony of the Endowments from beginning to end.

Jan. 15: We set apart nine missionaries to Mexico and ordained seven to the office of Seventies. Brigham Young Jr. and myself wrote out a part of the Ceremony of the Endowment. We rode out in the afternoon. Got the horses down in a mud hole. Got three quails and came home. I spent the evening with President Young. He told me there was no necessity of dressing in the temple clothing while giving the 'second anointing' any more than in administering the first anointing or ordaining. He also said that we should use the Bible in the 'Garden' and Bible and

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Book of Mormon in the ‘Telestial Room,’ and add the covenants to it in the ‘Terrestrial Room’

Wilford Woodruff spent the day of January 16 in the Temple giving “second anointings.” Henry Lunt, being a Bishop, Stake President and Stake Patriarch, could have been involved in this. There were 132 baptisms and confirmations for the dead.⁹ Wilford Woodruff referred, in his journal, to some by name and many by numbers for the “days work” in the Temple.

On September 13, 1876, the jury in the second trial of John D. Lee found him guilty of murder in the first degree. The case was appealed to the Supreme Court, but this tribunal sustained the decision of the lower court and Lee was sentenced to be shot, and was executed about 25 miles from St. George, March 23, 1877, on Monument Point at Mountain Meadows, the scene of his crime.¹⁰ This took place just two weeks before the April General Conference and the momentous dedication held in the St. George Temple.

1. Latter-day Saints Millennial Star, Jan. 5, 1875 issue, (Cedar City, Utah Public Library), Vol. 7, p. 10.
2. Utah Historical Quarterly, Spring of 1995, Vol. 63 No. 2, p. 155.
3. Andrew L. Neff, History of Utah, 1847-1869, (Salt Lake City, Utah: The Deseret News Press, 1940), Chapter XIX, p. 431.
4. Rhoda Wood, “History File,” S.U.U. Special Collections Library, Cedar City, Utah, p. 54.
5. C. J. Arthur, “C. J. Arthur Journal,” L.D.S. Church File, Salt Lake City, UT, p. 16.
6. Ellen W. Lunt, “Cedar Ward Relief Society Minutes,” Entry for June 3, 1875, L.D.S. History Library, Salt Lake City, Utah.
7. Matthias Cowley, Wilford Woodruff, (Salt Lake City, Ut: Bookcraft, 1964) p. 491.
8. Janice DeMille, The St. George Temple First 100 Years, Entry for Jan. 1, 1877, (1977).
9. Wilford Woodruff, Wilford Woodruff Journal, Jan. 16, 1877 Entry, S.U.U. Special Collections Library, Cedar City, Utah.
10. Andrew L. Neff, History of Utah, 1847-1869, (Salt Lake City, Utah: The Deseret News Press, 1940), p. 432.